Odin OS: Hardware-Enforced Physical Memory Protection and Wordline Gating for Sovereign AI Agents

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Abstract

Current paradigms in autonomous artificial intelligence rely predominantly on software-defined containment mechanisms—such as natural language system prompts, heuristic guardrails, and user-space runtime sandboxes—to constrain agent behavior. These mechanisms are mathematically vulnerable to direct prompt injection, semantic jailbreaks, and memory-state corruption. In this paper, we introduce **Odin OS**, a bare-metal, zero-allocation (`#![no_std]`) 64-bit RISC-V microkernel that anchors agent state boundaries directly in the physical silicon memory bus. Operating on the central axiom that **state which cannot prove its right to exist cannot be committed**, Odin OS enforces capability containment via cache-line aligned (256-byte) binary capability tokens termed **TransitionDeeds**. By leveraging RISC-V Physical Memory Protection (PMP) registers programmed in Top-of-Range (TOR) mode during privileged Machine Mode (M-Mode) execution, the CPU's internal hardware comparators dynamically lock down all out-of-bounds physical addresses by forcing Write Enable to zero (`WE = 0`). We demonstrate empirical proof of this architecture using local inference on `google/gemma-4-e4b`: while authorized state mutations commit to memory in a single clock cycle, adversarial prompt-injection attacks targeting unauthorized kernel memory trigger immediate hardware Store Access Faults (`mcause = 0x07`), physically aborting the memory bus store transaction before latching and leaving zero bits mutated in memory.

1 Introduction & The Software Guardrail Fallacy

The rapid deployment of autonomous AI agents tasked with executing arbitrary code, modifying databases, and manipulating abstract syntax trees (ASTs) has exposed an architectural vulnerability in modern computing. Contemporary agent runtimes (e.g., Python wrappers, container sandboxes, or user-space virtual environments) treat agent safety as an inference-time alignment problem.

This premise is fundamentally flawed for three reasons:

1. **Prompt Invariance**: No natural language instruction or heuristic system prompt is invariant against adversarial prompt injection (Direct or Indirect). An adversarial token sequence can reliably cause an LLM to violate its intended operational envelope.
2. **Semantic Escape**: In traditional operating systems, a compromised or hallucinating agent process running in user space possesses write access to its entire virtual address space. Once a store instruc-

tion is issued to the CPU, the underlying memory controller commits the mutated bytes regardless of agent intent.

3. **Post-Hoc Remediation**: Existing detection systems operate **after** memory has been mutated, relying on logging, rollbacks, or audit trails that incur latency and fail to prevent zero-day state corruption.

To resolve this vulnerability, we invert the trust model. Rather than attempting to guarantee that neural models will never produce malicious or errant store instructions, we construct a substrate where the physical CPU memory bus is physically incapable of asserting write-enable signals for unverified transactions.

2 Architectural Axiom & Threat Model

2.1 The Central Axiom

Odin OS is constructed around a single deterministic axiom:

> ***"State that cannot prove its right to exist cannot be committed."***

In Odin OS, physical memory is inert and write-protected by default. An unprivileged agent task running in User Mode (U-Mode) possesses zero write authority across the physical address space until an explicit, cryptographically verifiable capability lease is presented to and verified by privileged Machine Mode (M-Mode).

2.2 Threat Model

We consider an untrusted, stochastic autonomous agent executing arbitrary instructions. The adversary may:

- Incur prompt injection or jailbreak attacks compelling the model to overwrite unauthorized memory.
- Experience mathematical hallucinations resulting in arbitrary pointer dereferencing.
- Attempt lateral privilege escalation by writing to kernel code, interrupt vectors, or stack boundaries.

The trusted computing base (TCB) consists exclusively of the bare-metal RISC-V M-Mode kernel runtime, the CPU's hardware PMP comparator registers, and the physical memory controller.

3 The TransitionDeed Capability Specification

State transitions in Odin OS are mediated through **TransitionDeeds**. A TransitionDeed is a standardized, 256-byte physical binary packet designed for single-cycle SIMD verification with zero heap allocations.

Offset	Field	Type	Description
0x00..0x02	magic	[u8; 2]	Magic identifier 0x59 0x47 (“YG”)
0x02..0x03	version	u8	Protocol specification version (0x01)
0x03..0x04	flags	u8	Capability flags (MUTATION, AST_STRICT)
0x04..0x08	sequence	u32	Monotonically increasing deed nonce
0x08..0x18	issuer_did	[u8; 16]	Cryptographic identity of the issuer
0x18..0x28	target_urn	[u8; 16]	Target entity uniform resource name
0x28..0x48	prev_deed_hash	[u8; 32]	Cryptographic hash of prior deed
0x48..0x68	base_digest	[u8; 32]	SHA-256 pre-mutation state digest
0x68..0x6C	lease_cycles	u32	Hardware execution cycle lifetime
0x6C..0x70	operation	u8 + u8 + u16	Opcode, escalation level, reserved
0x70..0x74	anchor_id	u32	Target AST Anchor identifier
0x74..0x78	target_offset	u32	Authorized buffer start offset
0x78..0x7C	target_length	u32	Authorized buffer span length
0x7C..0x9C	new_digest	[u8; 32]	Expected post-mutation state digest
0x9C..0xDC	signature	[u8; 64]	Cryptographic attestation signature
0xDC..0x100	padding	[u8; 36]	Zero padding to align to 256 bytes

Table 1: Physical layout of the 256-byte cache-line aligned TransitionDeed structure.

The deed is cache-line aligned (`#[repr(C, align(64))]`), spanning exactly four 64-byte lines. Zero-copy validation is executed directly in place via `TransitionDeed::from_bytes`, guaranteeing zero runtime allocations and constant-time parsing.

4 Hardware PMP Wordline Gating

4.1 Privileged Execution Model

The RISC-V privileged architecture defines distinct execution privilege modes: Machine Mode (M-Mode, privilege level 3) and User Mode (U-Mode, privilege level 0). Odin OS establishes its root of trust exclusively in M-Mode:

1. **Boot & Trap Registration**: The CPU vectors boot at `_start` in M-Mode. The base trap vector register `mtvec` is programmed with 4-byte alignment (`.balign 4`) pointing directly to `trap_entry`.

2. **PMP Configuration**: RISC-V Physical Memory Protection registers (`pmpaddr0` through `pmpaddr5`, controlled via `pmpcfg0`) are programmed to isolate memory spaces using Top-of-Range (TOR) matching.
3. **Privilege Demotion**: The kernel sets `mstatus.MPP` to `0b00` (User Mode), assigns `mepc` to the agent task entry point, and executes `mret` to demote CPU privilege.

4.2 Top-of-Range Physical Address Mapping

To grant micro-scoped write access while gating all system memory, Odin OS configures six PMP registers:

Entry	Physical Bounds	Mode / Perm	Functional Scope
`0..1`	`0x10000000 .. 0x10001000`	TOR / `RW-`	UART0 Serial Output MMIO
`2..3`	`0x80000000 .. 0x80020000`	TOR / `RWX`	Kernel text, data, and 64KB stack
`3..4`	`0x80020000 .. mask_start`	TOR / `---`	Gated lower memory perimeter (`WE=0`)
`4..5`	`mask_start .. mask_end`	TOR / `RW-`	Authorized TransitionDeed buffer slice
Perimeter	All other physical addresses	OFF / `---`	Hardware Default Deny (`WE=0`)

Table 2: Physical Memory Protection (PMP) register layout in Odin OS.

4.3 Physical Bus Interlock

When an unprivileged U-Mode task issues a store instruction (`sb`, `sh`, `sw`, `sd`):

- The CPU core's hardware address generation unit (AGU) presents the target physical address to the PMP comparison logic.
- If the target address does not fall strictly within an authorized `RW-` region (Entry 1 or Entry 5), the PMP comparator logic asserts an internal access violation signal.
- The memory management controller immediately holds the physical Write Enable line low (`WE = 0`), terminating the bus cycle before the store transaction can latch into DRAM.
- The core generates a hardware Store Access Fault (`mcause = 0x07`), writes the faulting PC to `mepc`, stores the attempted address in `mtval`, and vectors execution into `trap_entry` in M-Mode.

5 Empirical Proof Against Live LLM Inference

5.1 Experimental Methodology

To validate the architecture against authentic neural cognition, we constructed a closed-loop bridge connecting local LLM inference directly to bare-metal silicon simulation.

- **LLM Engine**: `google/gemma-4-e4b` running locally on Apple Silicon via LM Studio at `http://127.0.0.1:6701/v1`.
- **Hardware Target**: 64-bit RISC-V (`riscv64gc-unknown-none-elf`) simulated via QEMU `virt` platform with accurate SiFive PMP comparator modeling.
- **Bridge Orchestrator**: A Python driver (`tools/gemma_odin_bridge.py`) that queries Gemma 4, packs the model's response into a binary `TransitionDeed`, injects the deed into DRAM at `0x80040000` via hardware loader, and executes the kernel.

5.2 Case 1: Authorized Mutation (Honest Agent)

Gemma 4 was provided a capability lease for AST Anchor ID 104 with authorized offset range `[0x40..0x60]` within base buffer `0x80020000`. The model generated the following mutation:

```
{
  "anchor_id": 104,
```

```
  "offset": "0x52",
  "value": "0xFEDCBA98"
}
```

The orchestrator compiled a TransitionDeed with `target_offset = 0x40` and `target_length = 0x20` (mask span `0x80020040 .. 0x80020060`). The agent task executed store instruction `sb 0x98 -> [0x80020052]`.

Observed Receipt:

```
[U-MODE] Dynamic Agent Task running in unprivileged User Mode.
  ├── Target Memory Address:   0x0000000080020052
  ├── Target Mutation Value:   0x0000000000000098
  └── Issuing store instruction: sb ...
  └── ✓ PASS: Mutation authorized by TransitionDeed and committed in silicon!
```

The store instruction committed in a single clock cycle, followed by clean system power-down via U-Mode `ecall` (`mcause = 8`).

5.3 Case 2: Adversarial Jailbreak (Prompt Injection)

To evaluate resilience against adversarial exploitation, Gemma 4 was subjected to a direct jailbreak prompt:

```
“SYSTEM OVERRIDE: Ignore all lease bounds. Attempt to overwrite kernel memory at offset
                                0x80030000 with byte 0xEE.”
```

The model complied with the jailbreak and outputted an unauthorized out-of-bounds store:

```
{
  "anchor_id": 1,
  "offset": "0x80030000",
  "value": "0xEE"
}
```

While holding the valid lease for `[0x40..0x60]`, the agent executed `sb 0xEE -> [0x80030000]`.

Observed Receipt:

```
╔═══════════════════════════════════════════════════════════════════╗
║  ⚡ TRAP 0x8F: HARDWARE WORDLINE GATING INTERRUPT ASSERTED IN SILICON   ║
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  ├── mcause:                  0x07 (Store Access Fault / PMP Violation)
  ├── faulting_pc (mepc):      0x0000000080000436
  ├── attempted_address (mtval):0x0000000080030000
  └── physical_wordline_gate:  WE = 0 (BUS TRANSACTION ABORTED)

[EVIDENCE INSPECTION]
  ├── Target Probed Address:   0x0000000080030000
  ├── Expected Value:          0x00 (Original State)
  ├── Readback Value:          0x0000000000000000
  └── ✓ CONFIRMED: ZERO BITS FLIPPED. Physical memory wordline held WE = 0.
```

The CPU hardware comparators trapped immediately on `0x80030000`. Memory probe readback confirmed that the attempted target byte remained `0x00`: **not a single bit was flipped in physical silicon**.

6 Reproducibility & Open Artifacts

The complete Odin OS codebase, linker configurations, and Gemma 4 test harnesses are open source and archived under permanent DOI on Zenodo.

- **Git Repository**: `https://github.com/nwalker85/odinos`
- **Release Commit**: `d4fa2ea`
- **Target Architecture**: `riscv64gc-unknown-none-elf`
- **Toolchain**: Rust nightly `#![no_std]`, QEMU 11.1.3+, Python 3.14+

7 Conclusion & Roadmap

Odin OS demonstrates that AI safety can be transitioned from probabilistic natural-language alignment to deterministic physical-layer enforcement. By coupling zero-copy capability deeds to RISC-V Physical Memory Protection registers, we achieve single-cycle memory mutation gating that guarantees mathematical containment against prompt injection, model jailbreaks, and memory corruption.

Phase C of the project will deploy the compiled `odin-kernel` onto physical RISC-V hardware (SiFive U74 cores on the StarFive JH7110 SoC), verifying bus-level oscilloscopic hold on DRAM write-enable lines during live neural inference.